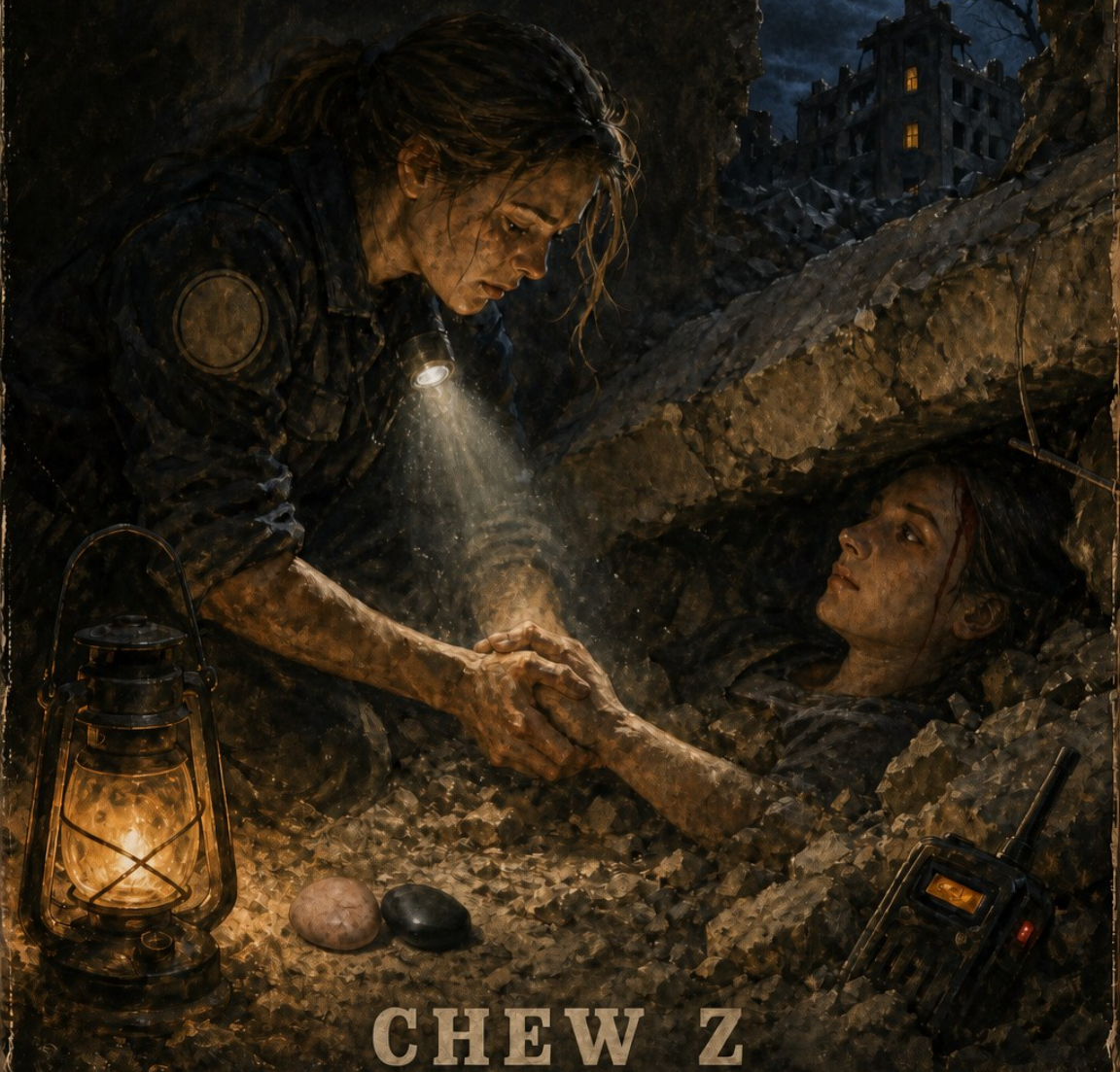


**ROYA**  
PUBLICATION  
No. 11

# THE MARRIAGE OF STONES



**CHEW Z**

• A ROYA PUBLICATION •

# **THE MARRIAGE OF STONES**

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 11

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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TWO PAIRS. ONE INHERITED, ONE ASSEMBLED.  
THE DIFFERENCE IS THE WHOLE PRACTICE.

## SYNOPSIS

Reyhan does not experience time in order any more. Cold stone against skin, a stranger's grip, a certain slant of afternoon light — each is a trapdoor back to some other year of her life. She has built a private discipline around the dislocation: teaching the powerful and the damaged a total literacy in their own bodies, using paired stones, one rose and one black, as instruments as precise as a stethoscope.

What none of her clients know, because she has never once said it out loud, is that the stones are not a therapy. They are a clock. Since the night a building came down on her she has not been able to tell warm from cold with any reliability, and her sense of when she is went out with it, and she presses a stone to her skin to find out what year it is.

Forty minutes of that night are the spine of everything she has built since. She spent them lying on her front in the wreckage with her arm through a gap in the concrete, holding the hand of an old woman she had never met, who knew exactly what was happening to her and talked about the weather.

Eight years later, a client asks her a question she has never answered, and her hands go cold before she understands why.

## A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

There is a phrase that has become common shorthand in trauma research: the body keeps the score. I did not set out to illustrate a textbook, but the idea kept returning to me while I wrote this book — that what happens to us does not stay in the past the way memory pretends it does. It lodges. It waits in the tissue, in the reflexes, in the places we stop letting ourselves feel. Time, for the traumatised, is not a line. It is a loop with trapdoors.

That idea owes an obvious debt to Kurt Vonnegut, whose *Slaughterhouse-Five* taught a generation of readers that some experiences are too large for chronology — that a person can become unstuck from time not as a fantastical device but as the truest way to describe what it feels like to survive something. I wanted to write a trauma story that moved the way trauma actually moves: sideways, backward, arriving uninvited.

What I did not expect, when I started, was how much of the book would turn out to be about bookkeeping. Not the metaphor — the literal thing. If the body keeps the score, then it is keeping a record, and a record implies a filing system, and a filing system can be corrupted. Reyhan's is. Hers files by temperature, and the index is broken, and the whole apparatus she built afterward is a workaround for a piece of damaged equipment she has never once described honestly to another person.

The other thing I did not expect was how long the forty minutes would take to write. I had assumed the collapse was the engine and the rest was the book. It turned out to be the reverse. Most of what happens down there is nothing — waiting, shifting a numb arm, the weather, a song neither of them can name — and the nothing is the point. There is no way to be honest about a night like that and also make it brief. I stopped trying.

And a third: how ordinary the worst damage is. The man who trained her occupies a very small part of this book, which is not an accident. He did not break her. He did something smaller and more

common, which is that he found a woman who had already built something out of her own wreckage, and gave it a vocabulary, and then behaved for two years as though the vocabulary were the thing. I wanted him sized correctly. He is an episode, not an origin. The origin is forty minutes long and it has an old woman in it.

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## CHAPTER ONE

*Now.*

The room is not what people expect. No incense, no silk, no candlelight arranged for effect. A single lamp, amber-shaded, throws a low light across a floor mat and two cushions. On a low table between them: a lacquered box, and inside it, wrapped in undyed linen, two stones.

Reyhan does not speak first. She has learned that the first person to speak in this room is the one still performing a self they have not finished building. She lets the client sit. Lets him notice the silence has weight. Most people, faced with quiet this total, start negotiating with it — filling it, apologising to it. He does neither. He simply waits her out, the way a man waits out a market he intends to buy.

She likes him already. She distrusts liking him. Both are useful information.

“You said on the phone you wanted to understand your own body,” she says. “Not increase pleasure. Understand it.”

“Aren’t those the same thing?”

“No. One is furniture. The other is architecture.”

He almost smiles.

She opens the box and takes out the black stone, and before she hands it to him she does what she always does, which is press it flat against the inside of her own left wrist for the length of one breath. He takes this for ceremony. Every client takes it for ceremony. It is the only genuinely functional gesture in the entire session and it has nothing to do with him.

Cold. Good. It is still this year.

## CHAPTER TWO

*Minutes one to four.*

Minute one.

The void is roughly the size and shape of a bathtub laid on its side, and Reyhan is in the wrong half of it. Above her, at an angle she does not like, a floor slab has come down and stopped, caught on something she cannot see and has decided not to think about. The air is full of concrete dust so fine it does not fall so much as hang, and it has made everything — her mouth, her eyes, the inside of her nose — taste of a school corridor.

Somewhere ahead and below, a hand comes out of the dark and finds hers.

It finds hers. That is the part she will be unable to describe accurately for eight years, and she does not notice it now, because she is busy, and because noticing is a thing you do afterward with equipment you do not currently have.

“What’s your name,” Reyhan asks, once the settling overhead goes quiet enough for words to survive it.

“Does it matter now.”

“It matters to me.”

A pause the length of a held breath.

“Alma.”

“Alma,” Reyhan says, and files it the way she files everything — except this one, she already knows, she will keep.

Minute two.

Neither of them says anything for a while.

Reyhan lets it sit, because she has already learned, in eleven years, that the first silence after an agreement like this one is not a silence that needs fixing. It is the sound of two people finding out whether the agreement is going to hold.

Somewhere behind her, a stretcher wheel catches on debris and shrieks once, briefly, and is gone. Alma’s thumb moves once across

the back of Reyhan's hand, small, almost accidental, and Reyhan understands it as a test — are you still there, is this still happening the way you said it would — and does not move away from it.

She runs the assessment she is not going to say out loud. Airway: clear. Breathing: fast, shallow at the top, which could be the dust and could be the chest. Colour: impossible, in this light, in this dark, under this much grey. Capillary refill: she will check it later, when there is a later, when checking it will not be a thing Alma can see her deciding to do.

The slab above them makes a sound like a chair being pushed back in another room.

Minute three.

"Talk to me," Alma says. "Not about — " She does not finish the sentence. She does not have to.

"About what, then."

"Anything. Weather. I don't care. Just don't let it go quiet."

So Reyhan talks about the weather, because it is the smallest true thing she has. Two days ago, she says, it rained in the afternoon and stopped by six, and the pavement outside her flat steamed for twenty minutes afterward, and she stood at the window and watched it and did not do the three things she had come home to do.

"What were the three things."

"I don't remember. That's what I'm telling you. I stood there twenty minutes and I have no idea what I was supposed to be doing."

"Good," Alma says. "That's the right way round."

Minute four.

Above them, work starts. Not near. Somewhere up and to the left, a long way through the stack, something heavy is being persuaded to move and is arguing about it. Every few seconds there is a sound Reyhan recognises as hydraulics and a sound she recognises as men, and between those, nothing.

"How long have you been doing this," Alma asks.

"Eleven years."

"Are you good at it."

Reyhan considers lying, and finds, slightly to her own surprise, that she cannot be bothered.

"I'm very good at it."

"Then I'm glad it's you," Alma says, and there is nothing in her voice that is trying to make Reyhan feel anything, which is exactly why it works.

### CHAPTER THREE

*Eight years before.*

The call comes in at 4:12 in the afternoon and is at first a building, which is a category, and then a number, which is a different category, and then a street name, which is the one that changes the temperature in the vehicle.

Nobody says anything on the way. This is not solemnity. It is arithmetic. Four of them in the back doing the same sum independently and arriving, at slightly different speeds, at the same answer, which is that there is a shape to the day now and everything else has been cancelled.

Reyhan is thirty-one. She has eleven years and a reputation for hands — for being the one who can find a vein in a bad light, for the specific unhurried competence that makes a frightened person decide, without being told, to stop fighting. She has never once thought of this as a thing that could be taken from her. It is not a skill she has. It is a fact about her, like height.

What she will remember of the approach is not the building. It is a woman standing on the far pavement in a dressing gown holding a bag of shopping, and the shopping is the thing, because it means she went out, and while she was out the arithmetic of her whole life changed, and she has come back with the shopping.



## CHAPTER FOUR

*Minutes five to eleven.*

Minute five.

"Are you hurt," Alma says. "You. Not me."

"No."

"You'd say that anyway."

"I would," Reyhan agrees. "But no."

Minute six.

The truth, which she does not offer, is that her right shoulder is at an angle her right shoulder does not usually achieve, and that the position she has got herself into — flat, arm down, cheek against a surface that is either floor or wall — is one she will not be able to hold for forty minutes.

She holds it for forty minutes.

Minute seven.

Dust comes down in a slow curtain from somewhere overhead and they both stop talking until it stops, which takes longer than either of them expects. What is left drifts down in single flakes, catching what little light there is, and for a stretch of time Reyhan cannot later account for, she simply watches it fall across the small visible triangle of Alma's face, because watching it is easier than watching anything else in the room.

Minute seven.

It arrives twice. She notices, at the time, that it arrives twice. She checks her watch, which is not on her wrist, because she took it off in the vehicle, which she does not remember doing and would not have done. She decides to start the count again from where she thinks she is and to be honest with herself about the fact that the count is now an estimate.

The count is now an estimate. She keeps it anyway. It is the only instrument she has left that still reports.

Minute eight.

"Tell me about the sheets," Alma says.

"What sheets."

"You said it rained. Did you have washing out."

"No."

"I did," Alma says. "Tuesday. Two sheets and a blue shirt that isn't mine. Still out there, probably."

"Probably."

"They'll be filthy now."

"They'll be filthy now," Reyhan agrees.

Minute nine.

Nothing.

Minute ten.

Nothing. Somewhere a long way off a radio says four words Reyhan cannot make out and then says nothing further, and the silence after it is somehow louder than the silence before it was.

Minute eleven.

"What's your name," Alma says. "I've asked you that."

"You haven't."

"Haven't I."

"No."

A pause.

"Reyhan."

"That's a good name," Alma says, as though assessing a coat. "Say it again."

"Reyhan."

"Good." Her grip shifts, resettling, the way a hand does when it has decided to be here for a while and wants to find a more sustainable way to hold on. "I'll remember that."

She does not remember it. She asks again at minute nineteen and again at minute thirty. Reyhan answers all three times in the same

voice, because the alternative is to tell a woman in a hole that her head is going, and there is no version of that sentence that is worth the eleven seconds it would take to say.

## CHAPTER FIVE

*Now.*

The second session, and he arrives with a notebook, which she permits for exactly as long as it takes him to understand that she is not going to say anything worth writing down.

"Most of my clients," she says, "come in wanting a technique. Something they can practise in a hotel room in Frankfurt and feel they are making progress at."

"And you don't teach one."

"I teach one. It doesn't work the way you're going to want it to."

She puts the rose stone in his left hand and the black in his right and asks him, without explanation, which one is warmer. He says the left. He says it immediately, the way a man answers a question he believes is a formality.

"Try again. Slower."

He tries again. Takes longer. Says the left, with less certainty.

"Now put them down and tell me what the room smells like."

He cannot. He has been in the room twice and he cannot produce a single fact about it that is not about her.

"That," Reyhan says, "is the technique. You have spent forty years building an instrument that reports upward and never inward. We are going to find out, over about nine weeks, whether it still goes both ways."

What she does not say: that she has asked the warmer question of eight hundred people and roughly half of them get it wrong, and the half who get it wrong are not damaged, they are ordinary, and the number is the only clinical data she has ever collected that genuinely frightens her. The instrument fails in almost everybody. Almost nobody finds out.

## CHAPTER SIX

*Minutes twelve to nineteen.*

Minute twelve.

Nothing.

Minute thirteen.

Nothing. Reyhan's arm has begun the process it will complete somewhere around minute twenty, which is to stop being an arm and become a length of something that reports pain from one end only.

Minute fourteen.

"You can let go for a minute," Alma says. "I won't tell anyone."

"I'm fine."

"You're not, but suit yourself."

Minute fifteen.

The agreement is unspoken and neither of them will ever describe it, but it is this: nothing true gets said unless Alma is the one who says it first. Reyhan has worked out, somewhere in the first four minutes, that this is a woman who will not tolerate being managed and will tolerate almost anything else, and so she stops managing, which is the single most difficult professional decision she has ever made and takes her approximately no time at all.

Minute sixteen.

"Do you have children," Alma says.

"No."

"Do you want them."

"I don't know."

"That's not an answer, it's a filing category."

Reyhan laughs — actually laughs, down there, with a floor on top of them — and the laugh comes out wrong and dusty and hurts her chest, and Alma makes a small satisfied noise as though she has won something.

Minute seventeen.

Nothing.

A long nothing. Long enough that Reyhan becomes aware of the particular sound of her own swallowing, and of a piece of grit that has been under her left hip since minute two and which she has not been able to do anything about and will not be able to do anything about, and which will leave a bruise she finds four days later in the shower and stands looking at for some time.

The thing nobody tells you about the worst night of a person's life is how much of it is waiting. Not drama. Not a montage. Just two people in the dark, running out of subjects, while somewhere overhead men who are very good at their jobs proceed at a pace that is correct and unbearable at the same time.

Minute eighteen.

"There was a song," Alma says.

"What song."

"I don't know. That's why I said there was a song." A breath. "It was on when it started. In the kitchen. It had been on maybe a minute and I was about to change it because I didn't like it, and now I'd like to know what it was."

"Sing some."

"I can't sing."

"Neither can I. Sing some."

What Alma produces is four bars, off-key, mostly breath, and it is not a song Reyhan knows and never becomes one. She hums it back anyway. Gets it wrong. Alma corrects her. She gets it wrong again in a different place.

They do this for most of a minute, in the dark, under a building, while a woman dies by degrees, and Reyhan will think about it for the rest of her life.

Minute nineteen.

Nothing.



## CHAPTER SEVEN

### *The apprenticeship.*

She finds him the way people find anyone: badly, at the wrong time, on somebody else's recommendation.

By then she has been doing it alone for two years. The stones are already hers. The cold-first discipline is already hers, worked out on her own kitchen floor over eleven months of being unable to answer the question of what year it is without checking something external and physical. She has no name for any of it. She has never said it aloud to another person. She goes to him because she has read a description of what he teaches and recognised, with a lurch, that somebody has a vocabulary for the thing she has been doing in private like a woman with a habit.

He has a room with no furniture and an east-facing window and a floor he sweeps himself. He says, "Sit," and means it structurally, and she recognises the instruction because she got there first.

What he gives her, and it is not nothing, is language. Front border and back border. The idea that a boundary is a thing you draw rather than a thing that is drawn on you. The word married, for two objects that only make sense in relation to each other. She writes these down. Some of them are good. One or two of them she still uses.

What he does not do, in two years, is ask her a single question about where her own practice came from.

She notices this in month four and files it the way she files everything: irregular, worth watching, not yet actionable.



## CHAPTER EIGHT

*Minutes twenty to twenty-six.*

Minute twenty.

Her arm is gone. Not numb — gone, filed elsewhere, its return unscheduled. She shifts her weight a few degrees to take the ache out of one knee, without letting go, and Alma's eyes track the small movement, and something in her face, brief and almost embarrassed, might be gratitude that Reyhan is still uncomfortable enough, still human enough, to need to shift her weight at all.

Minute twenty-one.

"Tell me something you've never told anyone," Alma says.

"That's a big ask for a Tuesday."

"It's Thursday."

It is Thursday. Reyhan has been wrong about the day for six minutes without noticing, which is the first genuinely frightening thing that has happened to her tonight, and she decides on the spot never to mention it, and does not mention it for eight years.

Minute twenty-two.

So she does. Out loud, badly. Something about a smaller life, quieter, hands doing something slower than saving people, a room with a door that shuts. She does not have the shape of it yet — not really, not for another two years — but she says the vague outline of it into the dark anyway.

Alma listens to the whole thing without interrupting, which almost nobody does.

"Do it," she says, at the end.

"It's not a plan. It's a mood."

"Do it anyway. Moods are just plans that haven't been rude to anybody yet."

Minute twenty-three.

Nothing.

Minute twenty-four.

Reyhan catches herself wondering whether she turned the stove off.

She is lying under eleven thousand tonnes of a building, holding the hand of a dying woman, and some administrative sub-basement of her brain has raised a query about the stove, and will not withdraw it, and requires an answer.

She is ashamed of this for eight years. It is the single thing about that night she has never said to anyone, including, eventually, the man who will spend two years training her to say things like that to him.

Minute twenty-four, still.

The query about the stove does not go away. It is joined, after a while, by a second query about whether she locked the door of the vehicle, and a third about a message she did not answer on Sunday, and the three of them sit there in a row like people waiting at a counter, and the counter is not open, and they wait anyway.

She has read about this. Everyone who does this job has read about this. It has a name and a mechanism and a perfectly respectable literature, and knowing all of that turns out to be worth precisely nothing at half past four in the afternoon under a floor slab, which is the first lesson of the night and not the last.

Minute twenty-five.

"You've gone quiet," Alma says.

"Sorry."

"Don't be sorry, be here. Where'd you go."

"Nowhere. My kitchen."

There is a pause, and then Alma laughs — a real one, small and cracked and entirely unexpected — and says, "Oh, thank God. I thought it was just me. I've been thinking about a pan."

Minute twenty-six.

They talk about the pan for a while.



## CHAPTER NINE

*Now.*

Session four. He tells her, without being asked, about his father, and she lets him, and at the end of it she says nothing at all for long enough that he starts to look for the exit in her face.

"I'm not going to do anything with that," she says.

"Then why did you let me say it?"

"Because you needed to find out whether I would." She puts the stones back in the box. "There are people who will take that story and hand you an interpretation of it, and you will feel, for about nine days, as though something has happened. I'm not one of them. I'm interested in your hands."

"That's a very expensive way to be uninterested in me."

"Yes," Reyhan says. "It is."

## CHAPTER TEN

*Minutes twenty-seven to thirty-three.*

Minute twenty-seven.

The colour has started at the nail beds.

Reyhan looks down at their two hands — she has been avoiding it, which is its own kind of tell — and sees exactly what Alma has already diagnosed herself: the colour starting at the nail beds, patient and unhurried, doing the one thing it always does, the thing Reyhan has watched a hundred times in a hundred rooms with better lighting and a chair.

Neither of them mentions it. This is not denial. It is manners.

Minute twenty-eight.

"Is it going to hurt," Alma says.

"No."

"Don't."

"It might," Reyhan says. "Toward the end it sometimes does, and then it stops, and the stopping isn't the bad part."

"Thank you," Alma says, and means it, and they both understand that the first answer was the lie and the second was the apology and that the whole transaction took nine seconds and was the most honest thing either of them has said all night.

Minute twenty-nine.

Nothing.

Then, without any lead-in: "I was a seamstress. Forty-one years. Alterations, mostly, at the end — nobody has things made any more, they have things taken in."

"Were you good at it?"

"I was very good at it," Alma says, and there is a small satisfaction in it that Reyhan recognises as her own, turned up out of somebody else's life, and which she finds she cannot look at directly.

"Say something you were good at. Specifically."

"A blind hem," Alma says. "On a heavy coat. Where you can't see it on either side and the coat still hangs right." A pause. "Nobody ever says thank you for a blind hem. That's how you know it's good."

Minute thirty.

Above them, the work changes character. It gets closer and it gets slower, which Reyhan knows is the correct order and hates anyway.

"They're coming," she says.

"I know."

"They'll be another while."

"I know that too." Alma's grip shifts again — not weaker yet, just different, like something recalibrating for a longer haul than it had originally planned on. "Stop telling me things I know. You're better when you're just talking."

Minute thirty-one.

So Reyhan talks. The weather again, because she has run out and is not too proud to repeat herself. The sheets on the line. The song, humming a few bars of it under her breath just to keep some sound moving through the space between them, because silence, she is beginning to understand, is not restful down here. It is a thing that arrives and takes up room.

Minute thirty-two.

Alma's breath goes uneven for four full seconds and then evens back out.

Reyhan counts those seconds. Silently, the way she will count nearly everything for the rest of her life, and she does not say a word, and Alma does not say a word, and the count goes into a file that will not be opened for eight years.

Minute thirty-three.

"Will you tell someone I wasn't on my own," Alma says.

"Yes."

"Not for me. I don't care. For them."

“Yes.”

“Good.”

## CHAPTER ELEVEN

*Minute thirty-four.*

The grip has gone slack twice now and come back twice, and Reyhan has started counting the come-backs instead of the minutes, because the minutes have stopped being reliable.

"Your hands," Alma says.

"What about them."

"They're cold." Somewhere above them a generator starts, runs for four seconds and stops. "I keep thinking you're holding mine."

"I am."

"No." No weight on it at all, the way you would correct someone about a bus route. "I've had yours since the start. You should know that. In case it matters later."

Reyhan says something back.

She will spend eight years failing to recover what it was. It had the word all right in it, she thinks. Or the word okay. Something professional. Something with one hand already reaching for the next minute.

The dust comes down again and they wait it out and the thing that has just been said to her goes where such things go, which is not away.



## CHAPTER TWELVE

*Minutes thirty-five to forty.*

Minute thirty-five.

"Cold," Alma says.

Reyhan shifts her own coat higher around Alma's shoulder with her free hand, a gesture she knows, clinically, changes nothing, and does it anyway, because some gestures are not for changing anything.

Minute thirty-six.

"Say the song again."

Reyhan says the song again. Hums it low and off-key and constant, the same four bars over and over, because it is the only structure left in the room that is not collapsing, and some part of her understands, without being told, that repetition itself is a kind of holding.

Minute thirty-seven.

There is something in Alma's free hand. Reyhan registers this without attending to it, the way you register a chair in a doorway you are carrying something through. A small movement. A transfer. A hand opening against her wrist and closing again.

She does not look. She is doing four other things.

Minute thirty-eight.

The gaps have got long enough that Reyhan starts filling them herself, quietly, without being asked. The weather. The sheets. The pan. The four bars. A blind hem on a heavy coat, described back to its owner slightly wrong, so that its owner has to correct her, which costs Alma eleven words and buys them both another forty seconds.

"Still here," Alma says, once, in the middle of it, not as a question.

"Still here."

Minute thirty-nine.

The hand in hers is still a hand, still warm in the specific, narrowing way a hand stays warm right up until it does not, and

Reyhan keeps talking anyway, softly, about nothing, about the rain two days ago, about the sheets, about a song neither of them ever learned the name of, because the agreement was that it would not go quiet, and she is not going to be the one who breaks it.

Minute forty.

She holds on for two minutes past use.

Nobody tells her to stop. Nobody has to. At some point a light arrives from the left, and a voice she knows says her name twice, and she says give me a minute, and they give her a minute, because they are good at their jobs and because there is nothing else in the world that needs doing at that exact moment that is more important than the minute.

When she finally gets her arm back it does not work for eleven days.

Nobody asks her what they talked about. She is not sure, afterward, what she would have said. Sheets, mostly. A pan. A song.

## CHAPTER THIRTEEN

### *The apprenticeship.*

Year two, and the method turns — or perhaps it was always this shape and she is only now developed enough to see it.

He begins asking her to teach the exercises back to him. To put the stones into his hands and describe his own borders to him while he holds them. It is presented as pedagogy. You learn a language by speaking it.

She accepts the framing for four months, and then the old cold triage-voice — the one that has been reliably right about rooms for thirteen years and has been quiet since the collapse — produces a single clear reading:

Every exercise he has ever framed as being for her benefit produces, without exception, an outcome that serves him.

She does not act on it. She checks it the way she was trained to check things: she runs it again the following week, and the week after, and it comes back the same both times.

What ends it is smaller than any of that. One evening he refers to her practice — hers, the thing she walked in the door already doing — as something she learned here. Not unkindly. Not even deliberately. He says it the way a man says a thing he has believed so long that the believing has worn smooth.

She leaves on an ordinary Tuesday. No scene. She simply does not go back, and two days later, then two weeks, the absence starts to feel less like avoidance and more like a diagnosis she is finally willing to write down herself.

She keeps the word married. She has decided she is allowed. He did not invent it either.

## CHAPTER FOURTEEN

*Seven years before.*

The hands come back wrong.

Not damaged. Every scan is clean, every nerve conduction study is boringly normal, and three separate consultants tell her, with the particular gentleness they reserve for people whose problem is not in the part they can photograph, that there is nothing physically wrong with her hands.

What is wrong with her hands is that they no longer report temperature in a way she can use. Cold arrives as pressure. Warm arrives, sometimes, as nothing at all. A cup of tea and a cup of water are two objects of identical character. She finds this out in a kitchen at two in the morning and stands there for a long time holding both.

And underneath that, worse, the thing she does not have a word for yet: she has stopped being reliably able to say when she is. Not amnesia. The opposite. Too much availability. She reaches for a Tuesday and gets four of them, from four different years, all equally present, none of them labelled.

She works it out alone, on her kitchen floor, over eleven months.

The discovery is not mystical and she has never once described it as such. It is this: cold is the only signal that still arrives on time. Warmth is contaminated — warmth is where the other years live, warmth is the trapdoor — but cold comes in clean, now, current, undeniable. If she puts something cold against her skin and attends to it properly, the year resolves.

She uses, in order: a spoon. A window. A bottle from the fridge. A tile.

And then, in the pocket of a coat she has not worn since, a stone.

There are two of them. One is a fragment of somebody's building, scorched along one face, which she remembers picking up and has never understood why. The other is a small rose-coloured pebble worn smooth, with a shallow dish polished into one face by a thumb

that was not hers, and she does not remember picking that one up at all.

She assumes, for seven years, that she must have.

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

*Now.*

Session eight, and he asks the question. They all ask it eventually, in one phrasing or another, usually around week seven, usually when they have stopped being frightened of her.

“Did this heal you? Or did you just get very good at hiding it?”

Reyhan could answer with the department line. She could answer with a decade of clinical distance.

Instead she says, “Do you want the long version?”

He says yes, and means it, and so for the first time in eight years — out loud, to another person, in order — she tells him about the forty minutes.

It takes most of an hour. She does not perform it. She tells it the way you would read out a list: the size of the void, the dust, the name, the agreement that nothing true gets said unless Alma says it first. The weather. The sheets. The song. The stove, and the pan, and the fact that both of them were thinking about their kitchens, which is either the worst thing about human beings or the best, and she has never been able to decide.

He does not write anything down. She notices that and is obscurely grateful.

She gets to minute thirty-three. Will you tell someone I wasn’t on my own.

And then she stops, because her hands have gone cold.

Not the room. Not the stones, which are in the box, on the table, untouched for forty minutes. Her own hands, both of them, going cold from the wrist down, fast, the way they have gone cold perhaps nine times in eight years, always without warning and always — she understands this only now, with a clarity that arrives like a struck bell — always when she is close to something.

The body has filed it. The body has been holding it the entire time. And the body, which does not use language and has no interest in her schedule, has chosen this Thursday to hand it back.

"Reyhan," the client says, from a long way off.

"I need a minute."

He gives her a minute. He is, it turns out, good at that. It is the only useful thing anyone has done for her in eight years and he has no idea he is doing it.

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

*Now.*

Here is what comes back, in Alma's voice, intact, in the dark behind her eyes, with a generator starting somewhere and running for four seconds and stopping:

I've had yours since the start.

And then, because the body files in bundles and not in items: You should know that. In case it matters later.

Reyhan sits on the floor of a quiet room in a building that is not falling down, with a man she is being paid by watching her from four feet away, and does the arithmetic she has managed not to do for eight years.

She had assumed she was the one holding on. She has assumed it so continuously, and built so much on top of it, that the assumption long ago stopped being a thought and became a floor. Every session in this room proceeds from it. The whole practice proceeds from it. She is the one who reaches into the dark and holds on, and other people are the ones who need holding, and the arrangement is clean, and she is paid, and nobody in eight years has ever once been asked to hold her.

An eighty-year-old woman with a floor on top of her, thirty-four minutes into dying, spent the strength she had left warming the hands of a stranger who was too busy to notice, and then told her so, plainly, and flagged it — in case it matters later — and the stranger said okay.

And the stone. The rose stone. The one with a thumb-dish polished into it by a thumb that was not hers, that she has told herself for seven years she must have picked up.

Minute thirty-seven. A small movement. A transfer. A hand opening against her wrist and closing again.

She was given it.

Reyhan puts both hands flat on the mat, because they are shaking, and because putting your hands flat on the floor is the first thing



she teaches and it turns out to work, and she cries — not the decorous kind, not the kind she would permit in this room, the other kind, the kind that comes up out of the chest in a way that is frankly humiliating in front of a client and which she does not stop. She has spent eight years teaching strangers to generate their own warmth.

She has never once managed it herself. Not once. Not in eight years. The warmth in her hand has been Alma's the entire time, handed over in the thirty-seventh minute by a dying woman with nothing left to give and no reason to give it, and Reyhan has been carrying it around in a lacquered box and charging people four hundred a session to hold it.

The client, who has understood none of this and all of it, says nothing at all.

He simply sits in it — genuinely, finally, unrehearsed — and she recognises the exact expression on his face, because she wore it once herself, in a room with no furniture, in front of an east-facing window, a very long time ago, and because she wore it once before that, in the dark, with a floor on top of her, and did not know what it was.

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

*Now.*

Alone, after the last client of the year, Reyhan sits on the floor mat with both stones in her open palms.

The black one is cold. It is always cold. It is a piece of a building that fell down and it has never once told her anything except the year, which is all she has ever asked of it, and it has never once been wrong.

The rose one is warm. It has been warm for years. She has held it perhaps four thousand times and assumed, in the unexamined way a person assumes the floor, that the warmth was coming from her.

She knows better now, and it does not help, and she has decided that not helping is not the same as not mattering.

She thinks about the word she kept. Married — two things that only make sense in relation to each other. She had always taken it to mean the stones. It does not mean the stones. It has never meant the stones. It means a building and a woman, which came down on her in the same hour and have been in the same room ever since, and cannot be told apart, and will not be separated by anything she is able to do about it.

She will tell someone Alma was not on her own. She has told nobody for eight years, because there was nobody to tell, because she never learned a surname and by the time she thought to ask, the asking would have required explaining why, and she had not yet understood why.

She thinks she will start with the client. He is not the right person. There is no right person. He is the person who sat in it.

Outside, it is raining, the way it was raining two days before everything came apart, and inside, in a room with one amber lamp, a woman who has finally learned to read her own pulse again holds two stones, one cold and one warm, and calls them, silently, by the only name that was ever entirely hers.

## **GLOSSARY**

Anahita [aa-naa-HEE-taa] — Ancient Iranian goddess of the waters, of healing and of wisdom, whose name carries the sense of the undefiled.

Asha [AA-shaa] — Avestan, truth, right order. The Zoroastrian principle of the truth that holds a structure together, as against the lie that costs nothing to tell.

Reyhan does not live her life in order. A stranger's grip, cold stone against skin, a certain slant of afternoon light — any of them is a trapdoor into another year of it.

She teaches the powerful to read their own bodies. Two stones, one pink and one black, one for the front border and one for the back. The cold comes first, because cold is the one fact a body cannot argue with.

Her new client has mastered everything except himself. The sessions are half seduction and half interrogation, and it is not always clear which of the two of them is being interrogated.

Underneath the work is an apprenticeship she has never described to anyone. Underneath that is a night in a collapsed building, forty minutes long, that her hands have never finished reporting.

*The mind will lie to you for free. The body has to be paid first.*

